Williams strikes out 13 as West-Oak rolls past Whitmire

By Caleb James

For The Journal

Westminster — A dominant performance on the mound and an early surge on offence powered The West-Oak High School baseball team to a 12-2 win over The Whitmire Highschool Wolverines Friday night.

Behind a career night from starting pitcher Jake Williams, the Warriors improved to 3-1 on the season while Whitmire fell to 2-5.

Williams controlled the game from the first pitch. After striking out the first two batters he faced and finishing the inning with a third strikeout, He set the tone for what became a memorable performance for him and his team.

West-Oak head coach Nick Groomes said Williams' performance was a testament to his toughness.

"He was a dawg on the mound tonight," Groomes said. "He went out and competed his tail off."

The Warriors quickly backed the stellar performance on the mound with some early offence.

Williams helped spark the first-inning rally with a leadoff single before Graham Campbell drew a walk. The Warriors aggressively advanced the runners with a double steal, and after loading the bases, West-Oak capitalized on Whitmire's control issues.

A hit batter and several wild pitches allowed the Warriors to plate four runs in the opening inning despite recording just one hit in the frame.

The early cushion allowed Williams to attack the strike zone. He racked up strikeouts throughout the night, including an impressive stretch where he recorded 11 consecutive strikeouts.

"My goal going out there was just to dominate," Williams said. "I injured my fingers lifting this morning, so we weren't sure how tonight was going to go. I just wanted to go out there, be gritty and do the best I could."

Whitmire briefly cut into the deficit in the third inning after taking advantage of some West-Oak defensive miscues to score twice.

But Williams quickly shut the door, striking out three straight batters to get out of the jam and regain momentum for the Warriors.

West-Oak answered immediately.

The Warriors added three more runs in the bottom half of the third inning on a combination of aggressive baserunning and productive outs, including sacrifice flies from Davis Cox and Williams.

West-Oak continued to build its lead in the fourth and fifth innings, highlighted by a run-scoring hit from Asher Evett that pushed the advantage into double digits.

Groomes said the offensive consistency has been an encouraging sign early in the season.

“We’ve scored close to 10 runs every game,” Groomes said. “We’ve got six freshmen and sophomores in the starting lineup, so getting them game reps right now is really important. I really like the makeup of this team, and they’re starting to gel together.”

Williams finished his outing with 14 strikeouts — a career high — before Parker Gibson worked the sixth inning in relief.

West-Oak ended the game shortly after when Skylar Maroney delivered a double down the left-field line to drive in the final run and secure the 12–2 victory.

The Warriors will return to action Wednesday at home against Powdersville before opening Region 1-3A play later this month against the Crescent Bulldogs.

West-Oak 12, Whitmire 2
WHS. 002 000 x — 2 3 4
WO. 403 311 x — 12 4 3

Pitching
WP — Williams, 5 IP, 3 H, 2 R, 1 BB, 13 K
LP — Alexander, 2 IP, 1 H, 5 R, 6 BB, 1 K
Hitting
WHS — Steele, 1-3, 1 RBI
WO — Evett, 2-4, 1R, 1RBI; Smith, 2-3, 2R